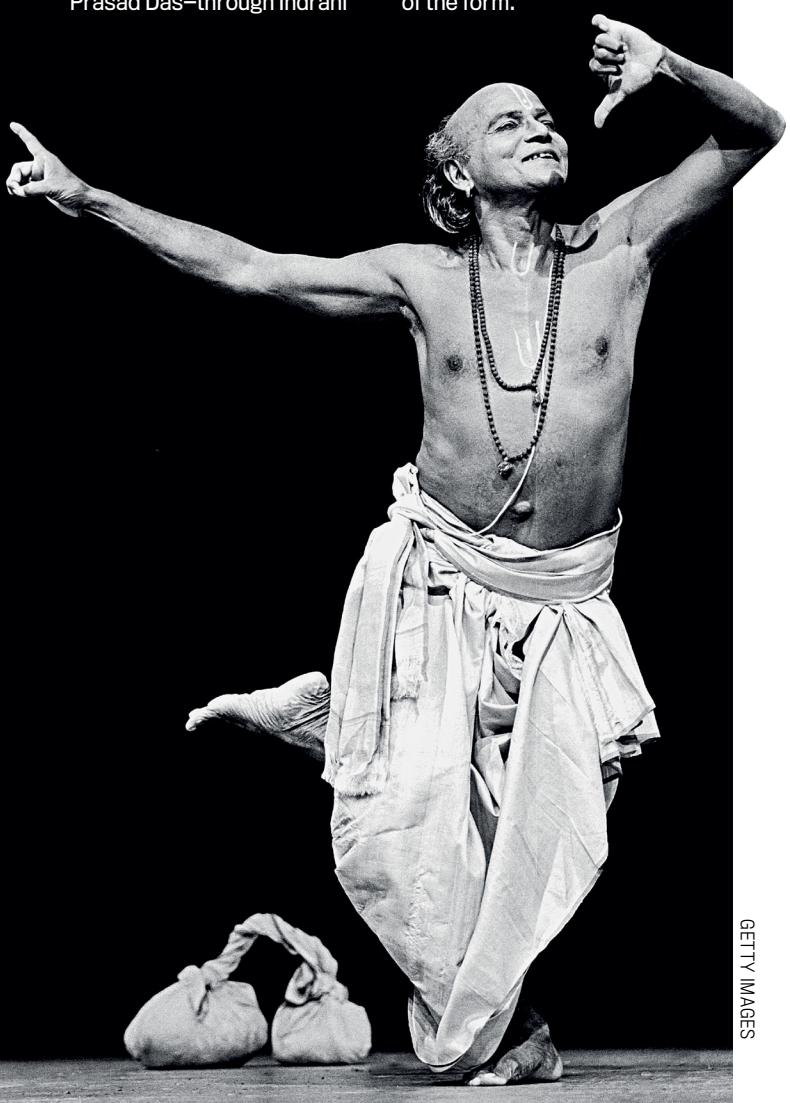
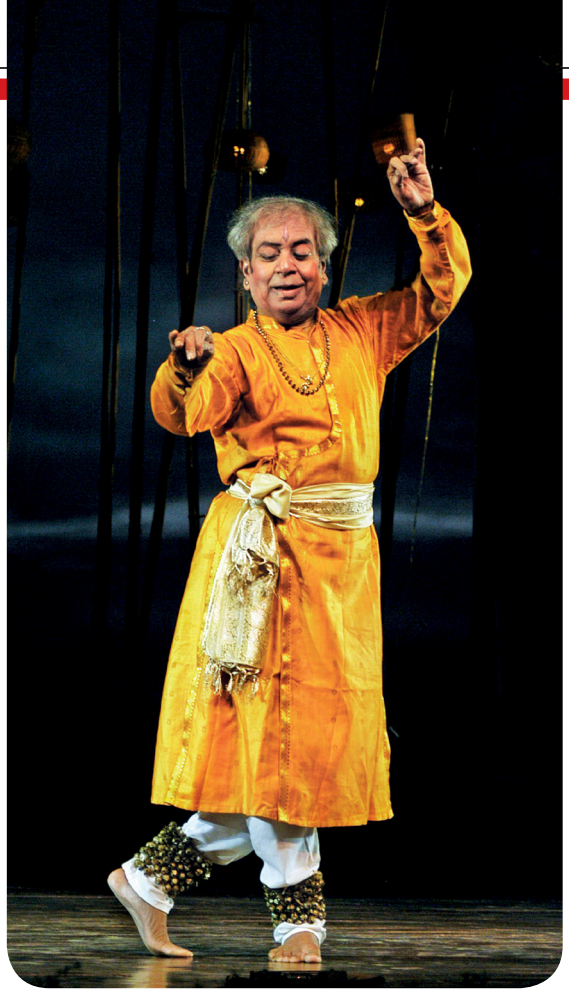
Kelucharan Mohapatra

(1926 -2004)

Born to pattachitra painters of Raghurajpur, Kelubabu, as he was known, made Odissi famous globally, along with his students Minati Das, Sanjukta Panigrahi, Madhavi Mudgal, Protima Bedi and more. He started off as an assistant at Annapurna theatre company, but once Odissi as a form was established, thanks to critics Charles Fabri and Mohan Khokar, he rode the wave in the 1980s and never looked back. Before him, Deba Prasad Das—through Indrani Rahman, Pankaj Charan Das, Yamini Krishnamurthy et al—had made Odissi popular in the 1960s. But once Kelubabu's disciples came of age, they brought him centrestage and he became a benchmark in himself. His mastery over music helped him create works of ever-lasting value. And though he resumed dancing in old age, he looked like a youth icon. His son and successor Ratikant has inherited his craft, while Ratikant's wife Sujata is the current star of the form.



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BANDEEP SINGH

Birju Maharaj

(1938 -2022)

He was first a prince of the Lucknow gharana, then the king of Kathak. He was Krishna, the ultimate romantic hero of Indian dance. Forever young, there was nothing light about his art—except when his eyes enacted the coquetry of the gods. A master of rhythm, scale, music and choreography, he was a complete artiste. He started off young in the court of Nawab of Rampur, then moved to Delhi with his father Achchan Maharaj and uncle Shambhu, and at the age of 13, he started teaching at Sangeet Bharati. His students are many: Bharati Gupta, Brojen Mukherjee, Shovana Narayan, Saswati Sen, Aditi Mangaldas, and then some. He trained three generations and more at the Kathak Kendra in Delhi, and at his private school Kala Ashram. His gifted children continue his work. Brij Mohan Mishra, popular as Birju Maharaj, teamed up with many leading dancers of his time, such as Sitara Devi, Kumudini Lakhia, Indrani Rahman, M.K. Saroja and, recently, Padma Subrahmanyam. His biggest contribution is choreography for dance dramas, which helped Kathak become a part of Bollywood culture, in a meaningful way.